Carlos César Chávez Padilla

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Development economist working on human capital and political economy, combining structural estimation with high-frequency data. Research Professional with James J. Heckman at the University of Chicago, and builder of Qhawarina, a real-time open-data platform for Peru.

Education

University of Chicago, Harris School of Public Policy 2024–2025
Master of Arts in Public Policy. *Merit Scholarship.*

Universidad Nacional Mayor de San Marcos (UNMSM) 2013–2017
B.A. in Economics. *Best Undergraduate Thesis.*

Universidad Nacional de Ingeniería 2018
Diplomas in Applied Econometrics and Finance.

Research Interests

Primary: Development Economics; Early Childhood Development. **Secondary:** Political Economy; Labor Economics.

Research Experience

Research Professional, Center for the Economics of Human Development, U. of Chicago 2025–present

- Work with Prof. James J. Heckman on early childhood skill formation and economic preferences.
- Research on how cognitive skills and personality traits relate to economic preferences in Chinese children, using structural modeling (CRRA and Expo-Power utilities).

Research Assistant, Harris School of Public Policy, U. of Chicago 2024–present

- With Prof. Christopher Blattman on gang recruitment in Colombia; with Prof. Martin Castillo-Quintana on game-theoretic models of extortion.

Pre-Doctoral Fellow, Georgetown University, McDonough School of Business 2023–2024

- With Prof. Amory Gethin on the political economy of social movements; built ML/NLP pipelines (DeBERTa transformers) on U.S. congressional records.

Research Analyst / Assistant, International Monetary Fund (MCM Department) 2020–2023

- Co-authored an IMF Working Paper on ethnic gaps and growth in Peru; research on political instability and macro outcomes across 180+ countries; supported country missions.

Earlier: Research Consultant, Inter-American Development Bank (2019–2020); Research Assistant, Universidad del Pacífico (2018–2019).

Selected Research

- **Relating Cognitive Skills and Personality Traits to Economic Preferences: Decision-Making under Cognitive Shocks and Guessing** (with S. Feng, J.J. Heckman, Z. Yang). *Accepted, Journal of Labor Economics.*
- **Did the Uruguay Round Spark Innovation? Evidence from Developing Countries Using Patent Data.** *Journal of Business.*
- **Auditing the Challenger: Legal Challenge Records as Adversarially Selected Forensic Samples.** *Under review, Election Law Journal.*

- **Cohort Effects of Democratization on Diffuse Regime Support and Emancipative Values.** *Under review, Political Behavior.*
- **Terrorism and Regional Development: Evidence from Peru's Internal War.** *Revise and resubmit, World Development.*
- **The Anatomy of a Nobel Prize.** *Revise and resubmit, Empirical Economics.*

Other Working Papers

- **How Economists Adopt Methods: Methodological Choice, Specialization, and Scientific Communities.**
- **The Diffusion of Econometric Methods: A Structural Model of the Credibility Revolution.**
- **Automation Is Not a Sufficient Statistic: Robots, AI, and Inequality.**
- **The Macroeconomic Consequences of Political Instability** (coups and TFP; Bjørnskov–Rode panel).
- **Missing Mass and Minimum Wages** (bunching estimator, Peru).
- **Identifying Monetary Policy Shocks in an Administered-Rate Economy: Evidence from Peru.**
- **The Shining Path of Violence: Long-term Effects on Human Capital in Peru.**
- **Spatial Sorting and Conflict Migration.**

Publications

- Chávez, C. (2024). Minimum Wage and Ethnic Gaps: Who are the Winners? *Journal of Economics, Race, and Policy*, 7(2), 93–121.
- Chávez, C. (2023). The Effects of Mining Presence on Inequality, Labor Income, and Poverty: Evidence from Peru. *Mineral Economics*, 36(4), 615–642.
- Chávez, C. (2023). Domestic Violence, Labor Market, and Minimum Wage: Theory and Evidence. *Review of Economics*, 74(3), 195–233.
- Chávez, C. (2020). The Impact of the El Niño Phenomenon on Dry-Forest-Dependent Communities' Welfare in Northern Peru. *Ecological Economics.*
- Chávez, C. (2024). Estimating the Effects of Financial Liberalisation on Governability and Social Stability. *Foreign Trade Review*, 59(4), 588–614.
- Chávez, C. (2024). Latin American Firm Cooperation Payoff Evidence. *The International Trade Journal.*
- Chávez, C., Salinas, G., & Yuri, Z. (2022). Closing Peru's Ethnic Gaps Amidst Sustained Economic Growth. *IMF Working Paper* 2022/180.

Full list at Google Scholar.

Writing

Essays on economics and econometric methods at carloschavezp29.substack.com. Selected essays and their use by others:

- **On Causality: A History of How Economics Learned to Think About Cause and Effect.** Course reading in PP338, Policy Design and Implementation (Robert Klitgaard), Claremont Graduate

University, Spring 2026. Recommended by Julian Reif on Bluesky and excerpted by Luke Froeb in Managerial Econ, February 2026.

- **Why Don't We Talk Enough About Marginal Treatment Effects?** Cited in the theory primer of the PyMTE Python package documentation as the recommended first reading on the MTE framework.
- **Why Macro Never Had a Credibility Revolution.** Summarized and discussed by David McKenzie in the World Bank's Development Impact blog, and discussed by Clint Ballinger in two essays (1, 2), January 2026.
- **Why Economists Linearize Everything.** Selected by Tyler Cowen for Marginal Revolution and quoted and discussed by Arnold Kling in In My Tribe, February 2026.
- **Why Christopher Sims Was So Great?** Selected by Tyler Cowen for Marginal Revolution, discussed by Arnold Kling in In My Tribe and translated into French by Martin Anota in Annotations, March 2026.
- **The Cowles Commission in Chicago.** Quoted on the Nanga Fakir economics blog, May 2026.

Honors, Conferences & Teaching

Honors: Merit Scholarship, U. of Chicago (2024); GSAS Future Leader Fellowship, Tufts (2023); Best Undergraduate Thesis, UNMSM (2017).

Conference presentations: NBER Summer Institute, Cambridge, MA (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); Midwest Econometrics Group Meeting (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); DePaul University, Chicago (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); Jinan University, Guangzhou (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); University College London (2026, with Feng, Heckman, Yang); Encuentro de Economistas, UNMSM, Lima (2026); IEA World Congress, Medellín (2023); LACEA–LAMES, Lima (2022); Bolivian Conference on Development Economics, La Paz (2022); Annual Conference of Peruvian Economists, Lima (2021–2022).

Teaching: Instructor, Universidad Nacional de Ingeniería — Econometric Theory, Econometrics I (2020–2022); TA, UNMSM — Microeconomics, Macroeconomics (2015–2018).

Skills & Affiliations

Programming: Stata, R (advanced); Python, Matlab (proficient). **Methods:** structural estimation, panel data econometrics, causal inference, instrumental variables, machine learning, NLP. **Languages:** Spanish (native), English (fluent). **Member:** AEA, Royal Economic Society, Econometric Society.

References

James J. Heckman — Henry Schultz Distinguished Service Professor, U. of Chicago, jjh@uchicago.edu.
Amory Gethin — Economist, Development Research Group, World Bank, agethin@worldbank.org.
Vincent Pons — Byron Wien Professor, Harvard Business School, vpons@hbs.edu.